Mike Dano | February 4, 2026

2025 Global Satellite Broadband Performance Report

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Low Earth Orbit (LEO) satellites – led by SpaceX's Starlink – are upending the market for space-based internet services across virtually every corner of the globe.

The satellite internet industry – which traces its origins back at least three decades – is now in a period of rapid evolution. The development of LEO satellites, which orbit much closer to the Earth's surface than traditional geostationary (GEO) satellites, has opened the door to services for consumers that are fast enough to support most modern digital activities, ranging from video conferencing to video gaming.

Starlink, the satellite internet constellation operated by rocket company SpaceX, has helped usher in this new reality. Launched commercially just five years ago, its rapid deployment of a massive LEO satellite network has quickly translated into market progress, allowing Starlink to capture a significant global customer base. It's a powerful case study in disruptive innovation.

Ookla's Speedtest Intelligence® data helps to capture the scope of this satellite market evolution and its effects on players around the world, as well as the scale of Starlink's growth and the extent of its networking improvements.

Key takeaways:

data. The company accounted for 97.1% of all global satellite Speedtest samples in the third quarter of 2025. Viasat came in a distant second with 1.7%. HughesNet was third globally with 1.0%.

- Speedtest data also provides a view into where Starlink's customers are located. The United States, Mexico, Indonesia, Brazil, and Canada are the company's top five markets, according to Speedtest sample counts – with the U.S. accounting for more than one in five Starlink samples. As for network performance, Starlink median download and upload speeds have been rising in all of its major markets.
- Starlink has also displayed clear improvements in its latency measurements in countries all over the globe. Starlink's highest latency – 282 ms in the Marshall Islands in the third quarter of 2025 – was still less than half that of the fastest GEO satellite latency measurements.
- In reaction to Starlink's growth, a number of incumbent GEO satellite operators have engaged in mergers and acquisitions. Those providing services to consumers – including Viasat and HughesNet – deliver download speeds roughly three times slower than those of Starlink in most big markets. Meanwhile, new LEO satellite players like Amazon Leo are seeking to capture a share of the market.

The race to space

The story of satellite internet is rooted in the dawn of the Space Age. The development of powerful, multi-stage rockets – initially for military and later for space exploration purposes – paved the way for placing objects into Earth orbit. Following the launch of the Soviet Union's Sputnik in 1957, the race to space culminated in the U.S. moon landing in 1969. These events helped set the stage for the deployment of the first communication satellites.

By the late 1990s and early 2000s, a handful of companies began leveraging satellite launch technology to offer internet access to consumers in areas unserved by telecom operators on the ground. Early pioneers, including WildBlue (later acquired by Viasat) and Hughes Network Systems (HughesNet), recognized the potential in using GEO satellites to connect the unconnected.

These early GEO systems were designed to cover wide swathes of the planet with a minimal number of satellites. However, such satellites must orbit at the same speed as the Earth's rotation, in order to maintain their position. To do so, they have to sit 22,236 miles above the Earth's surface. This distance between GEO satellites and Earthlings makes real-time applications, such as video conferencing and online gaming, challenging.

The GEO model dominated the satellite internet landscape for decades, mainly due to the steep costs involved with developing and launching satellites.

But things began to change roughly a decade ago. Unlike their GEO predecessors, LEO satellites orbit much closer to Earth, typically between 300 and 1,200 miles up. This speeds up connections – but it also means LEO satellite operators must launch lots of satellites. After all, at that orbit, a LEO satellite might complete a full circle around Earth in under two hours. Thus, keeping one specific location covered consistently requires multiple LEO satellites, each traveling over that location during a separate time period.

But before LEO satellites could disrupt the satellite internet market, first rockets needed to evolve.

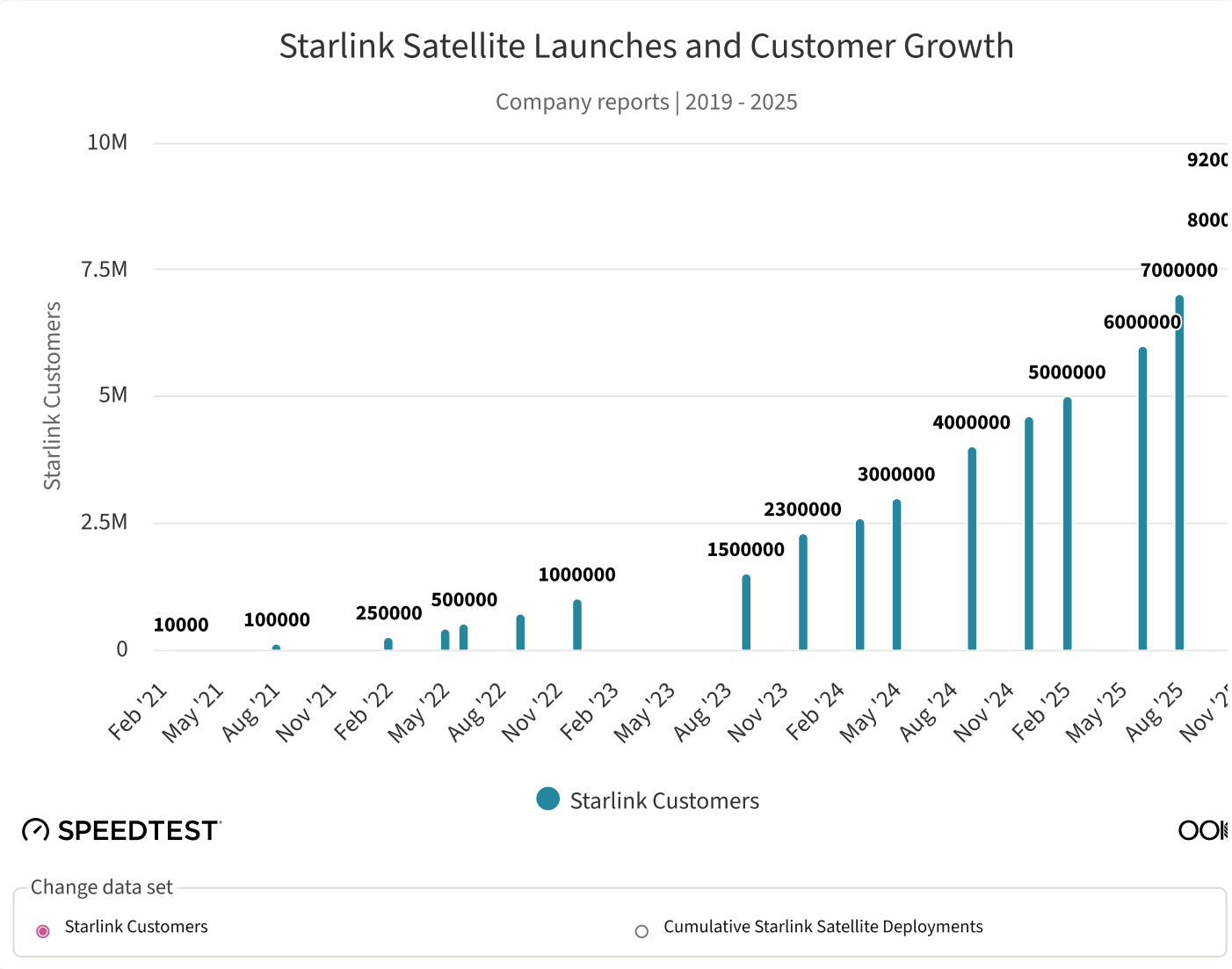
Tracking the rise of Starlink

The ascent of Starlink's service is directly linked to the cadence of SpaceX's rocket launches, now almost daily. Those launches are the figurative and literal engine of Starlink's global satellite internet expansion. Each successful launch –

supporting Starlink's growth and expansion.

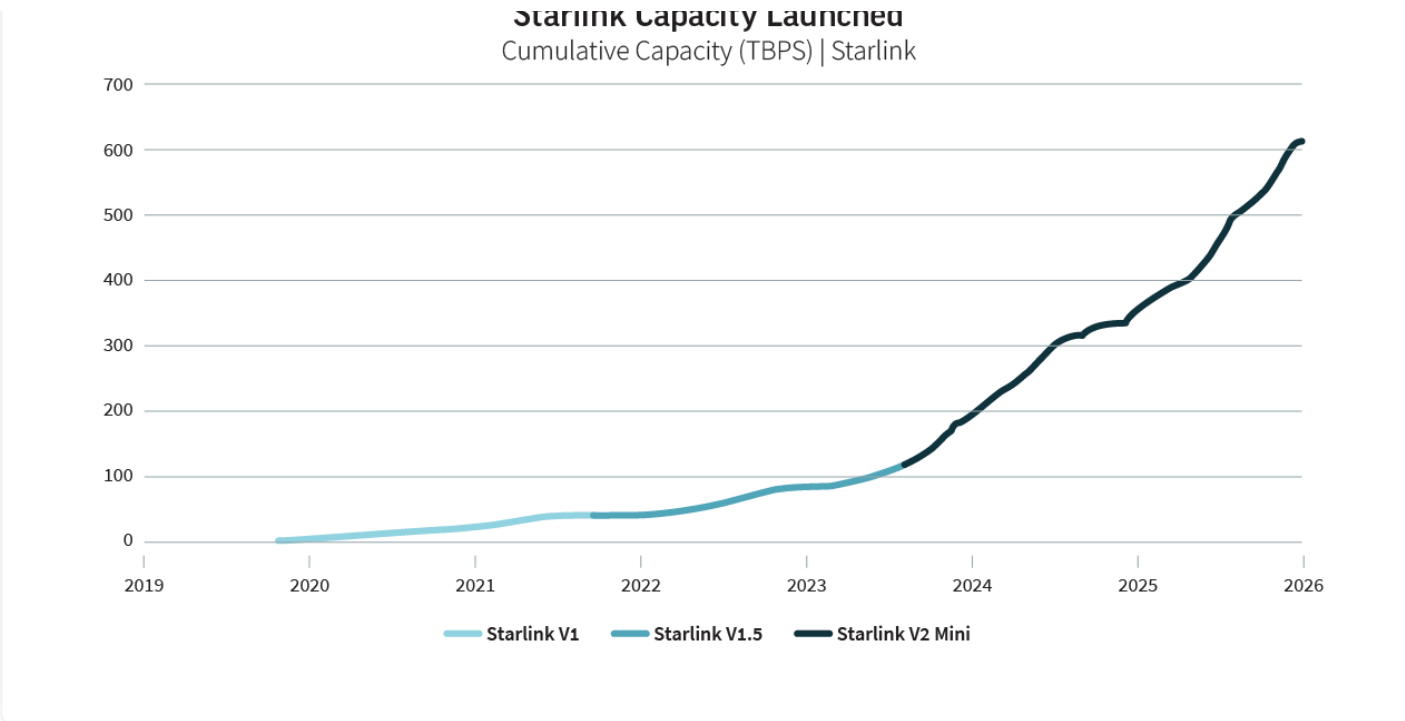
As noted by Space.com, SpaceX launched 165 orbital flights in 2025, which accounted for 85% of the United States' total tally. It's also twice as many as China. Starlink's satellites accounted for 123 of SpaceX's 165 Falcon 9 launches.

This operational rhythm is the single greatest differentiator for Starlink. As noted in its 2025 annual report, Starlink activated more than 35 new markets in 2025 while gaining 4.6 million additional customers.



Increases in Starlink's satellites and customers are commensurate with growth in traffic on the company's satellite internet network. According to Cloudflare, a global cloud infrastructure provider, Starlink's network traffic volume grew 2.3x across 2025.

Starlink itself has been working to stay ahead of that traffic. According to the company's 2025 report, its cumulative network capacity recently passed 600 Tbps.



All of this growth can be contrasted against some of the market's foremost traditional GEO satellite operators like Eutelsat OneWeb, SES, Viasat, and EchoStar. None has a consumer-oriented internet business that measures up to Starlink.

For example, Viasat counts around 157,000 satellite internet subscribers in the U.S., down from around 228,000 a year ago. The company does not disclose the number of customers it has outside of the U.S. And HughesNet, owned by EchoStar, counts roughly 783,000 satellite internet customers globally. That too is down from the 912,000 it counted a year ago.

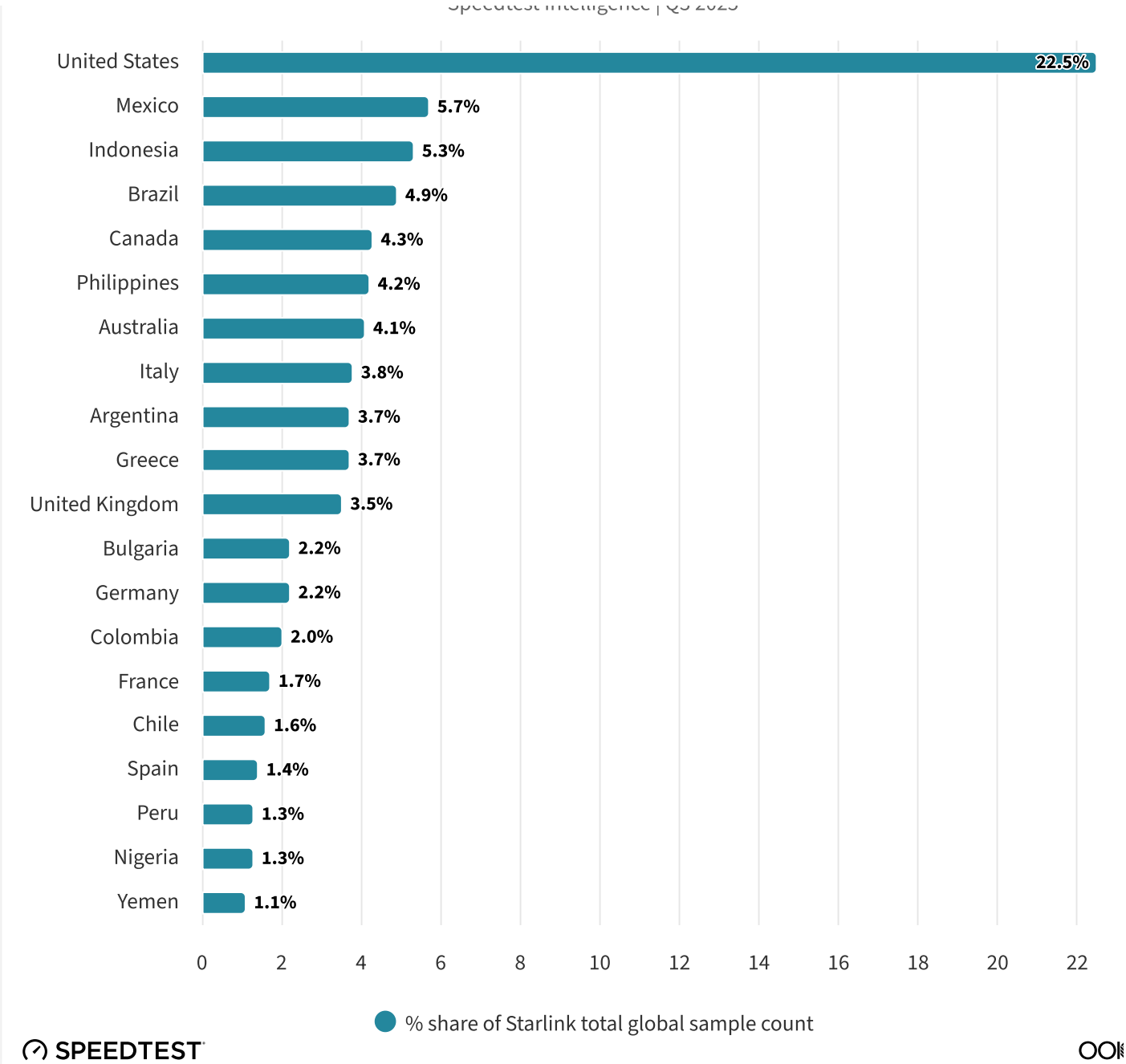
Indeed, according to PCMag, HughesNet is preparing to refer its own satellite internet customers to Starlink after its parent company, EchoStar, reached a deal to sell spectrum to SpaceX.

In general, Starlink's GEO rivals are increasingly shifting away from residential, consumer-focused internet services and toward wholesale services for business customers like governments, airplane operators, and maritime companies. For example, in its most recent earnings report, SES said its aviation business now serves 3,000 airplanes. And Viasat announced a new deal with U.S. Space Force Space Systems Command.

But here too Starlink is providing competition: Starlink recently reported it provides connections to a total of 1,400 commercial aircraft and 150,000 boats, including cruise ships, tankers, and fishing vessels.

Regardless, Starlink's success in the consumer-focused satellite internet business is clearly visible within Ookla Speedtest data. The company accounted for 97.1% of all global Speedtest samples in the third quarter of 2025. Viasat came in next with 1.7%. HughesNet was third globally with 1%.

Speedtest samples can also serve as a proxy for Starlink's global operations, shining a light on where the company's 9.2 million customers are located:



To be clear, these findings provide relative guidance and scale, but not exact customer figures. Just last week, a top Starlink official said the company now counts 1 million customers in Brazil, making it Starlink's second-largest market.

Still, it shouldn't come as a surprise that the U.S. accounts for around one out of every five Starlink samples – SpaceX is based in the U.S., and the U.S. was among the first markets where it launched Starlink services. But concerns over Starlink's growing satellite internet dominance are now pushing other countries to pursue their own sovereign satellite internet options.

Starlink speeds rise across top markets

The performance of Starlink's network varies around the world. In the third quarter of 2025, a diverse selection of relatively small countries recorded the globe's fastest aggregated median Starlink download speeds.

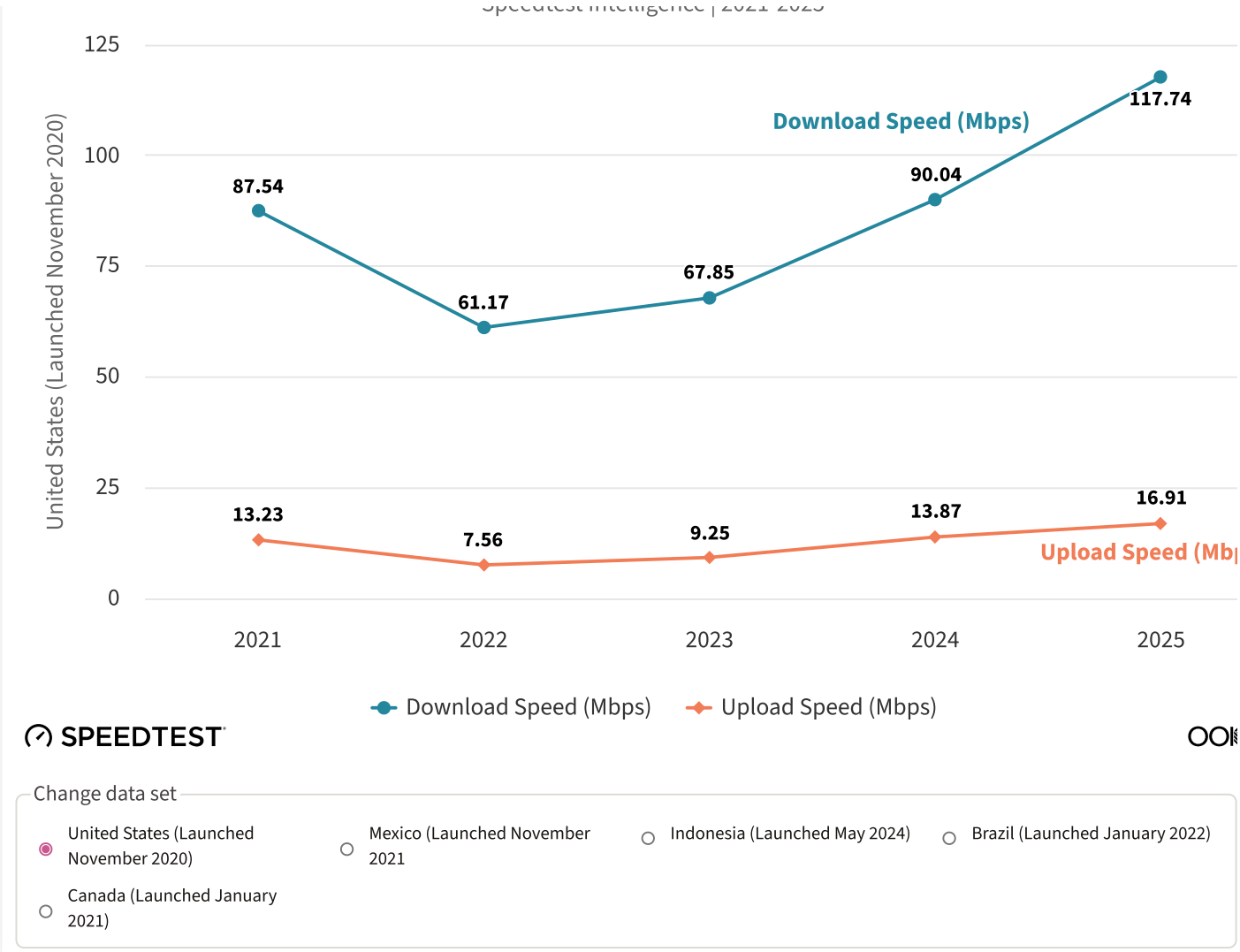
Latvia	187.30	April 2022
Northern Mariana Islands	186.15	November 2020
New Zealand	185.37	April 2021
Azerbaijan	182.44	March 2025
Portugal	180.18	August 2021

A similarly diverse mix of smaller countries made up the five slowest Starlink markets.

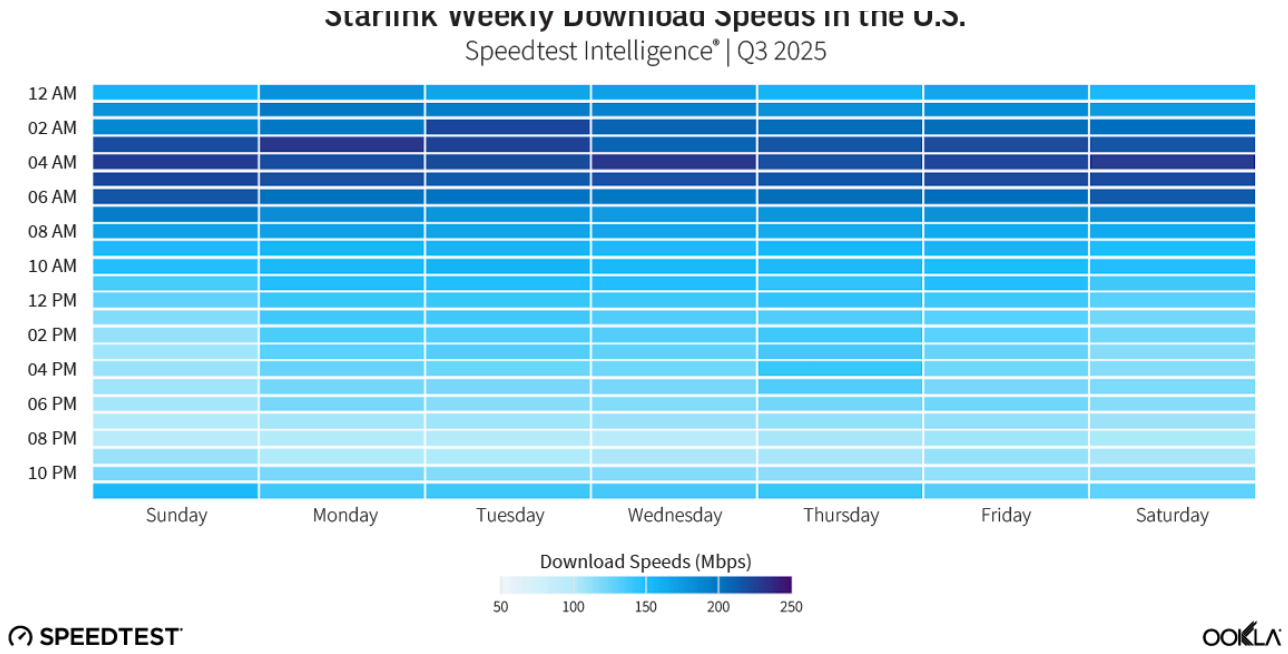
Country	**Q3 2025 Median Download Speed (Mbps)**	**Date Starlink launched**
South Sudan	15.87	August 2024
Madagascar	23.64	June 2024
Liberia	26.74	January 2025
Svalbard and Jan Mayen	27.80	February 2025
Yemen	28.07	September 2024

None of these countries is geographically near each other, considering they span from the middle of the African continent to the Arctic Circle. Thus, Starlink's speed variances could be due to a variety of other factors ranging from obstructions blocking users' receivers, or rain interfering with Starlink's satellite signals, to Starlink's network management efforts, and the placement of users' Wi-Fi routers in ways that slow connections.

In general, Starlink's top five markets show less variation in terms of speeds. They also show a general rise in overall median download and upload speeds.

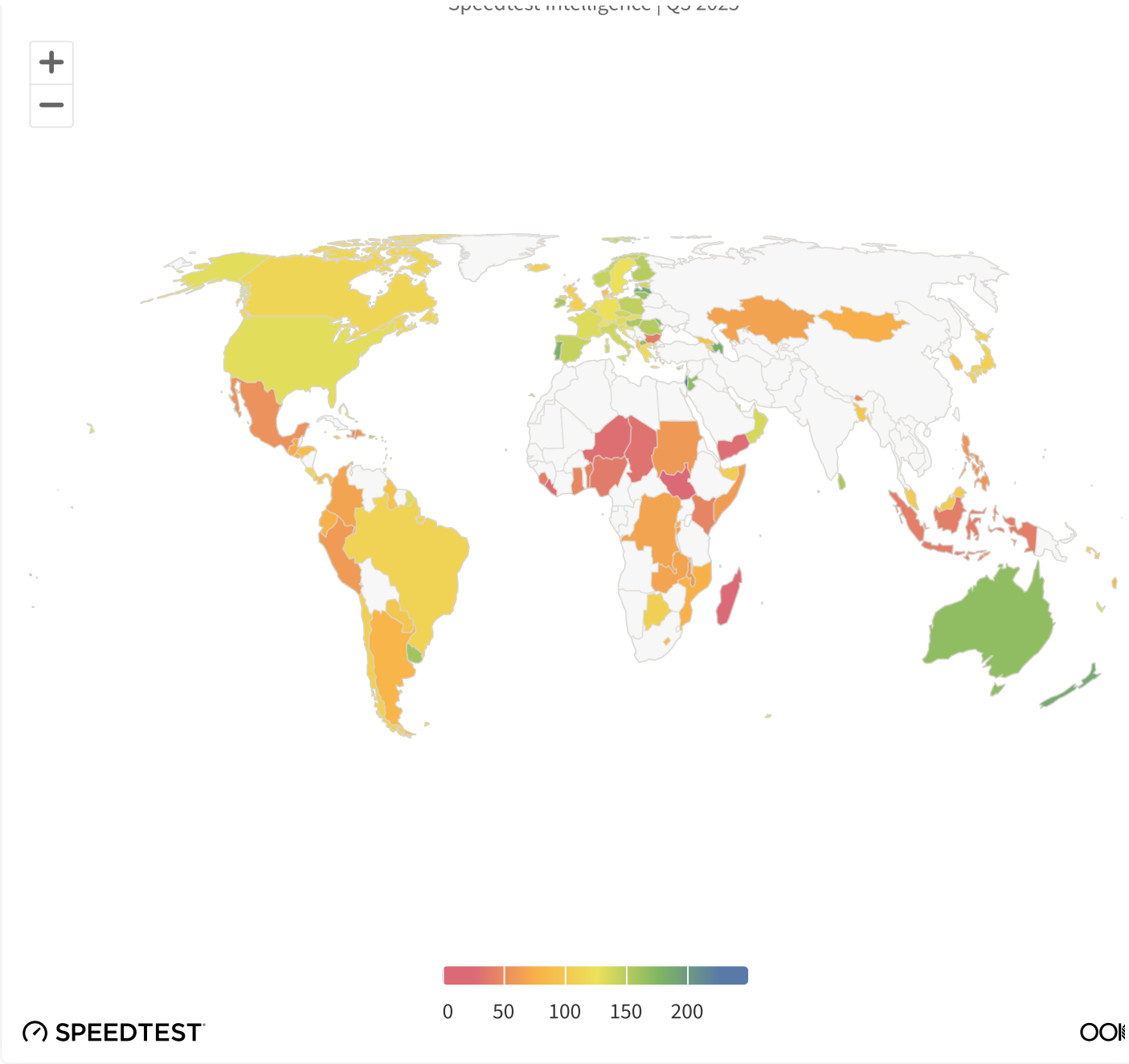


To be clear though, these speeds are aggregated across the span of months. Because Starlink is a finite, shared resource, users' network speeds can fluctuate on a daily – or even hourly – basis. This is simply due to the dynamic interplay between the company's network capacity supply and users' data demands. Speedtest data highlights this situation, showing speedier U.S. connections in the middle of the night, when few users are on the network:



In any case, Starlink's networking speeds make it an increasingly competitive option when compared with many local providers, even in developed markets. Moreover, the company's pricing has been falling even as its speeds have been rising. For example, in the U.K. Starlink's new £35 ($47 USD) per month plan for 100 Mbps speeds is slightly less expensive than a similar offering from BT, when setup and other costs are spread out over two years, according to the financial analysts at New Street Research. It's slightly more expensive than 100 Mbps fixed internet pricing from the likes of YouFibre and Vodafone.

Broadly, Starlink's global reach is noteworthy in its scope and scale. Indeed, the company launched commercial services in two new countries – South Korea and São Tomé and Príncipe – in December 2025.



Overall, Starlink today is available in more than 155 countries and markets.

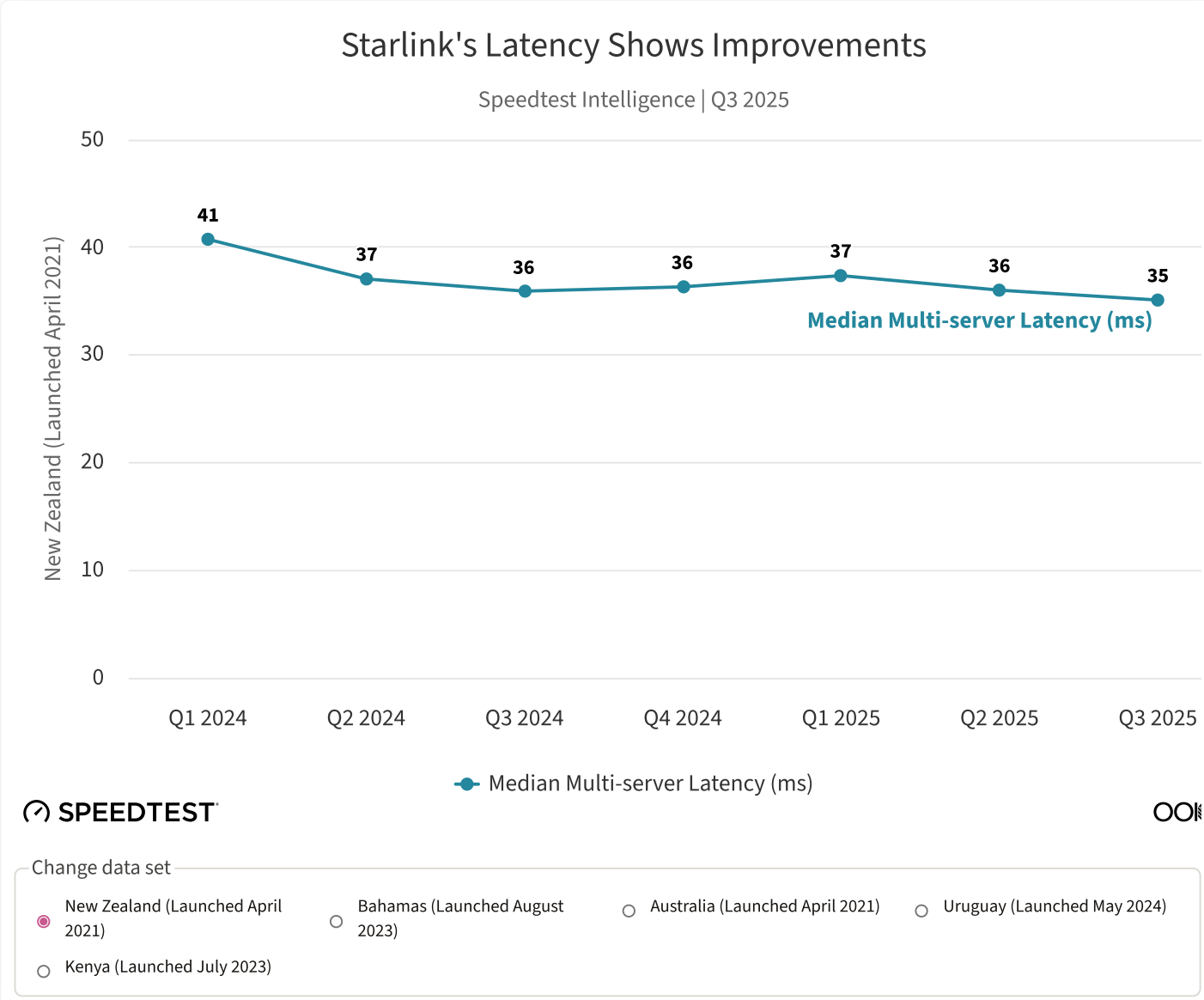
A closer look at Starlink's latency

Latency is the time between sending a request for internet data (clicking a link) and receiving a response (getting a web page). It's typically measured in milliseconds (ms). High latency causes noticeable lag, making real-time applications like video calls and online gaming frustrating. Low latency provides a snappier, more immediate user experience. Fixed networks on the ground, like those running through fiber connections, typically provide latency of 10 ms or below. Mobile networks, like those using 5G, often achieve latency of 30-40 ms.

Latency in Starlink's network is complicated by the fact that users' connections must travel roughly 341 miles above the Earth's surface, to where Starlink's satellites orbit.

can be introduced by a variety of other factors, including the laser links between Starlink satellites that can route traffic around congestion. Another major factor is the geographic distance between a user and a Starlink gateway site, which directs users' traffic onto the internet via a "point of presence," or PoP. Each hop of this journey – including transmissions across the internet itself – can add latency to a user's connection.

All of these factors – and more – are at play in the five Starlink markets showing the lowest latency in the third quarter of 2025: New Zealand, The Bahamas, Australia, Uruguay, and Kenya.



Broadly, Starlink continues to show latency improvements across the globe.

Interestingly, New Zealand has consistently ranked as the country with the lowest Starlink latency throughout 2025. That's likely due to the multiple ground stations Starlink operates throughout the country, coupled with New Zealand's relatively speedy, extensive, and robust fixed internet infrastructure.

But perhaps Kenya best illustrates the importance of nearby ground stations when it comes to Starlink's latency. A number of East African countries saw a significant improvement in Starlink latency early this year, likely linked to the deployment of a new Starlink PoP in Nairobi in January 2025. Prior to that deployment, Starlink's latency in Kenya was 289 ms. Afterward, it was just 53 ms.

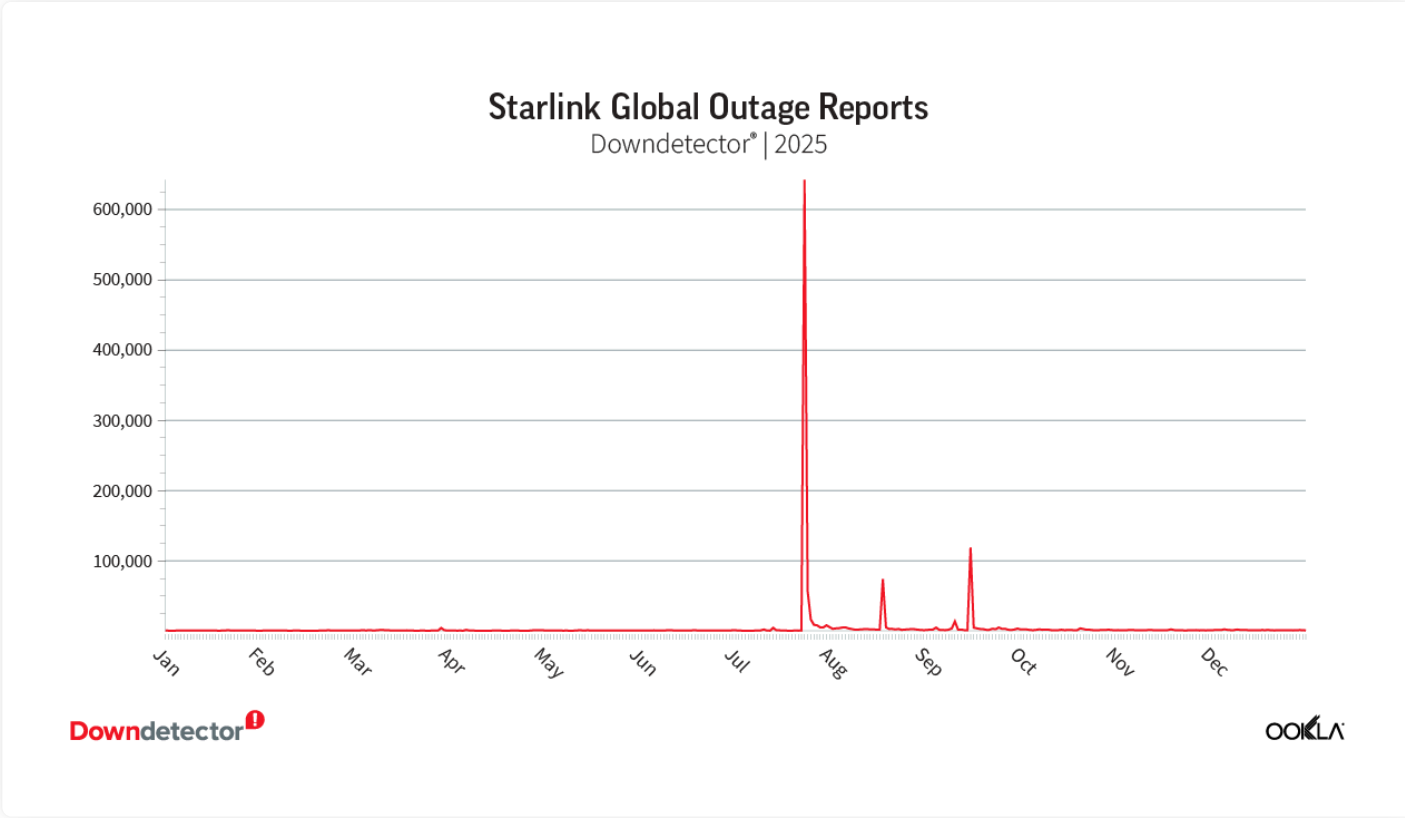
That focus could eventually lead the company to target the Marshall Islands, which showed the world's highest Starlink latency measurements (282 ms) in the third quarter of 2025, according to Speedtest data. This sprawling oceanic nation comprises more than 1,000 islands and 29 coral atolls, and is located roughly halfway between Hawaii and Australia. Not surprisingly, it struggles to support speedy internet connections, and possibly as a result it does not appear to host a Starlink ground station. The nearest Starlink ground station to the Marshall Islands appears to be located in Fiji, roughly 1,800 miles away.

Here it's worth noting that Starlink's highest latency measurement in the third quarter of 2025 was still less than half the best latency measurement Speedtest recorded for any GEO satellite internet provider during that period. Specifically, GEO satellite operator Kacific – which provides internet connections across the Asia-Pacific – notched a latency measurement of 599 ms in the Philippines in the third quarter of 2025. This isn't a surprise. GEO satellites orbit roughly 65 times farther away from their users than LEO satellites. This is the primary reason GEO satellite internet services have higher latency than LEO satellite services.

Nonetheless, Starlink isn't the only satellite internet provider investing in ground infrastructure. SES, Globalstar and AST SpaceMobile are among those satellite operators that have constructed new ground-based infrastructure. And Amazon Leo officials have said the emerging LEO satellite operator will have around 300 ground stations – or double the estimated 150 ground stations supporting Starlink.

One final element in an analysis of Starlink's operations involves the company's network resiliency – Starlink argues that its network can also be used as a backup in the case of emergencies. For example, Starlink said that its satellites used their laser links to maintain connectivity during the April 2025 power outage in Spain and Portugal.

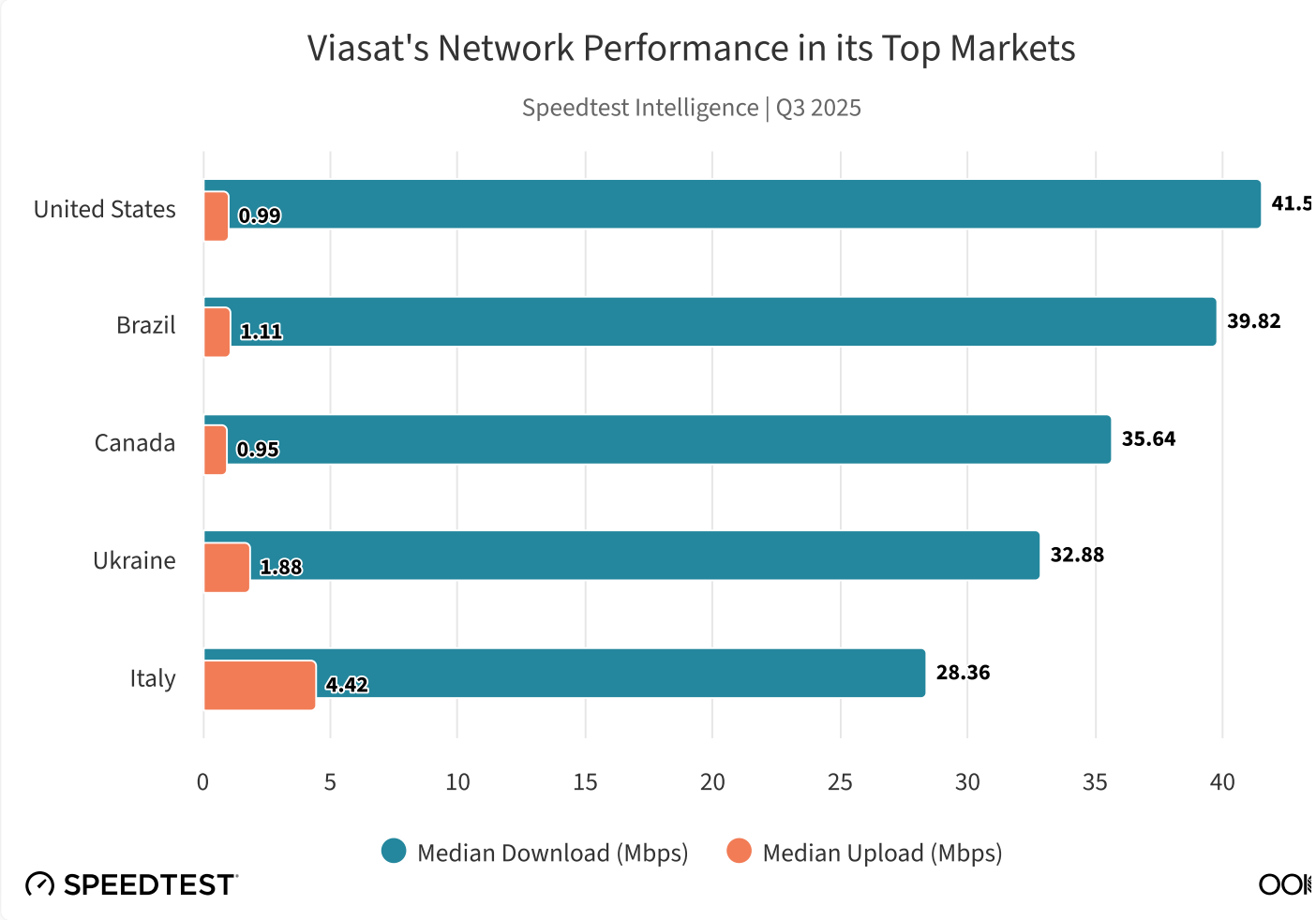
Ookla's DownDetector shows a handful of Starlink outage reports in 2025, on a global basis.



Evaluating the other satellite providers

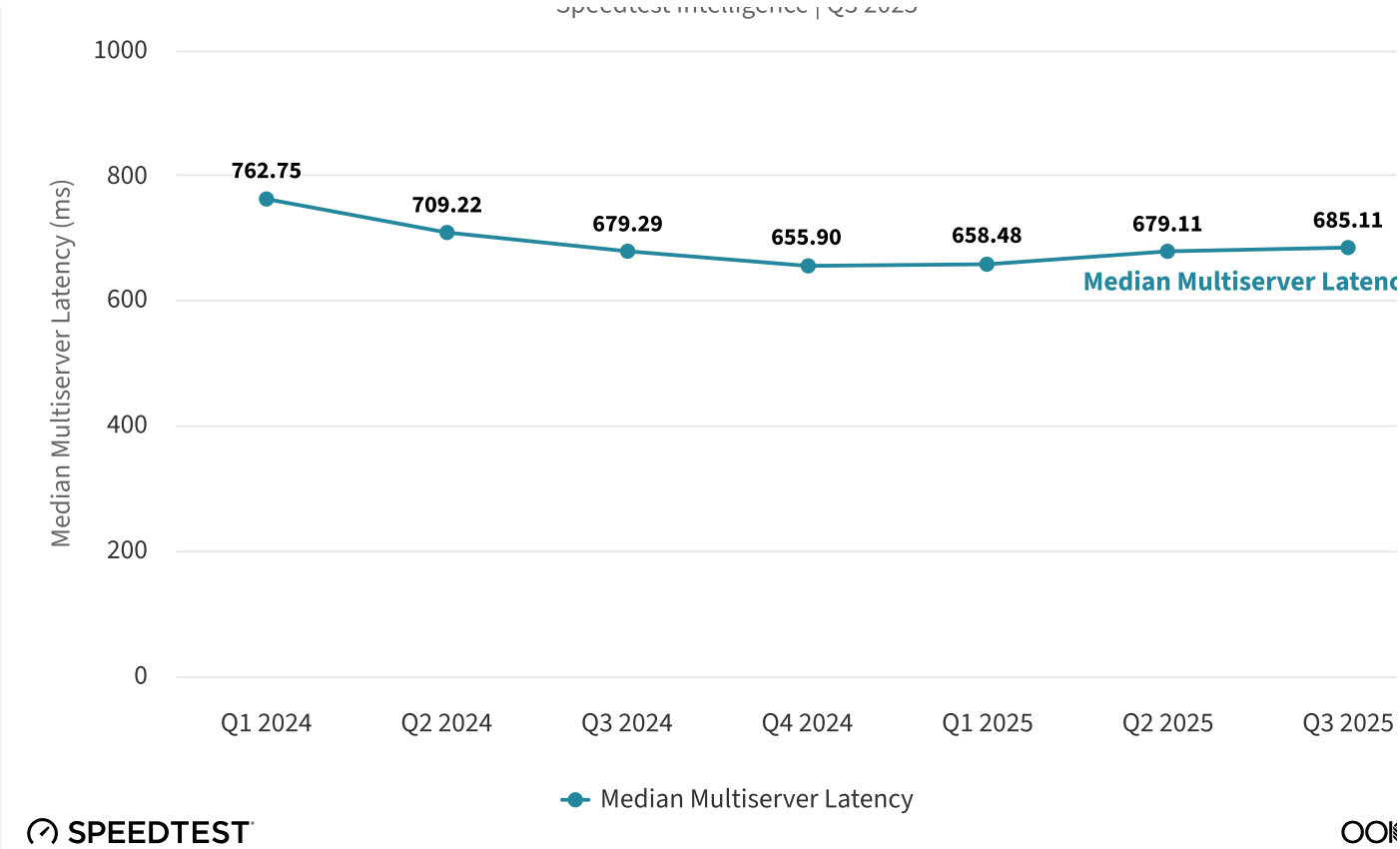
The U.S. was by far Viasat's top market in terms of Speedtest samples, accounting for 83% of results in the third quarter of 2025. Ukraine, Brazil, Italy, and Canada were Viasat's other top markets.

The U.S. also notched the fastest median download speeds on Viasat's network.



EchoStar's HughesNet showed similar results. The U.S. accounted for 72% of the company's Speedtest samples in the third quarter, and it also notched HughesNet's fastest median download speeds at 46.31 Mbps. Brazil, Colombia, Mexico, and Peru rounded out the company's top five markets.

Like Viasat, HughesNet generally showed latency between 600 and 800 ms across its network in the third quarter of 2025. In the U.S., the company's biggest market, HughesNet's latency hasn't shown much change during the past two years:



A handful of regional satellite operators also registered some results among Speedtest users. For example, Kacific saw samples in the Philippines, Australia, and Pakistan in the third quarter of 2025, with speeds and latency measurements similar to those of its fellow GEO satellite operators HughesNet and Viasat. Similarly, YahClick showed some samples in the United Arab Emirates, Pakistan, and South Africa, with performance similar to other GEO providers. YahClick is a Middle Eastern GEO satellite operator tied to Thuraya and Space42.

Latin American satellite operator Orbith also registered activity in Argentina and Mexico in the third quarter of 2025. However, its latency measurements in Mexico (38.66 ms) could reflect its efforts to add LEO satellite options alongside its existing GEO services. Orbith's latency results in Mexico were decidedly different from the 734.17 ms latency it posted in Argentina.

Broadly, Starlink's effect on the traditional GEO satellite market can be viewed through ongoing consolidation in the sector. For example, the combination of GEO satellite operator Eutelsat and OneWeb, an emerging LEO satellite player, was completed in September 2023. Another major combination – Viasat's acquisition of Inmarsat – was finalized in May 2023. And the merger of SES and Intelsat closed in July 2025.

What to expect next

While Starlink dominates the market for consumer-focused LEO satellite internet services today, that may not always be the case. Amazon Leo (formerly Project Kuiper) has been steadily building out its own LEO satellite constellation, and it is currently testing services across its roughly 180 satellites. The company hopes to launch more satellites in the coming months and years – a necessity as it works to present competition to Starlink. Amazon Leo has promised speeds ranging from 100 Mbps to 1 Gbps, based on the type of receiver a customer uses.

Lightspeed will be sold to business customers rather than consumers.

The latest: Rocket company Blue Origin said its TeraWave satellite internet constellation will ultimately span more than 5,000 satellites, providing services up to 6 Tbps. The company said it will begin launching satellites toward the end of 2027.

Most such efforts are focused on connecting satellites to customers' dedicated receivers. But a new dynamic in the sector – direct to device (D2D) – promises to expand the satellite internet market into smartphones. Here, companies like Lynk Global, AST SpaceMobile, Globalstar (partnered with Apple), and Starlink too are heavily investing into this evolving opportunity. According to surveys by Analysys Mason, up to 27% of respondents are willing to pay extra for these D2D services, thereby giving mobile network operators a 1% boost to their annual revenues.

However, all of these business models are contingent on satellite operators getting their satellites into orbit. Here Starlink is again the standout, considering its SpaceX parent is the world's leading satellite launch provider. But others – including United Launch Alliance (ULA) and Blue Origin – are scaling up to meet demand.

Starlink, of course, is not standing still. The company said its new V3 satellites, set to launch during 2026, will provide 10 times the downlink and 24 times the uplink capacity of the company's V2 satellites. And in support of those LEO satellite expansion plans, SpaceX continues to test its massive, reusable Starship rocket, which promises to deliver more satellites into orbit than any of SpaceX's previous rockets.

This continuous, aggressive upgrade cycle underscores Starlink's strategy to stay ahead of new market entrants by consistently increasing both the capacity and reliability of its global network. And that cycle could receive a major acceleration if SpaceX embarks on an initial public offering (IPO) during 2026.

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Satellite Starlink

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